

There are eight different ways to talk about the past in English. The differences between the past simple and the present perfect simple are particularly important.

See also:

Past simple **7** Present perfect simple **11**
Infinitives and participles **51**

The **past perfect simple** refers to an action or event that took place before another action or event in the past.

The game **had started** when I arrived at the stadium.

The **past perfect continuous** refers to a continuing action or event that was taking place before another action or event that happened in the past.

I **had been feeling** unwell for days, so I went to the doctor.

"**Used to**" and "**Would**" are used to talk about repeated actions in the past that no longer happen.

I **{ used to / would }** go to Spain every year.

"**Used to**" can also be used to refer to a fixed state at some indefinite time in the past that is no longer true.

I **used to** live in London.

"Live" is a state, so
"would" can't be used.

16.3 KEY LANGUAGE NARRATIVE TENSES

Narrative tenses are types of past tense that are used when telling a story.

The **past continuous** is used to set the scene. The **past simple** describes actions in the story.

The **past perfect** is used to talk about things that happened before the beginning of the story.

A crowd of people **were celebrating** the New Year when one of the young men **kneeled down** in front of his girlfriend and **asked** her to marry him. He **had planned** everything beforehand.

